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FIRST PHASE OF GAZA TRUCE BEGINS

■ UAE LEADS WORLD TO
WELCOME US-BROKERED DEAL

■ ISRAEL, HAMAS TO EXCHANGE
HOSTAGES AND PRISONERS

■ PALESTINIANS RELIEVED
AFTER NEWS OF CEASEFIRE

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

A breakthrough deal pausing the war in Gaza has been reached, with all parties signing the first phase of a ceasefire and hostage-release agreement — a major step toward ending a conflict that has killed tens of thousands.

Earlier, US President Donald Trump announced that Israel and Hamas had agreed on the first phase of a peace framework aimed at achieving a Gaza ceasefire and the release of Israeli hostages and Palestinian prisoners.

The announcement follows Trump's 20-point plan to end the Gaza war, unveiled last week and broadly welcomed by Israel, Hamas, and much of the international community.

"I am very proud to announce that Israel and Hamas have both signed off on the first phase of our Peace Plan," Trump said on his Truth Social platform. "This means that all of the hostages will be released very soon, and Israel will withdraw its troops to an agreed-upon line as the first steps toward a strong, durable, and everlasting peace."

Plea to both parties

Following the announcement, world leaders hailed the agreement as a major breakthrough, urging Israel and Hamas to fulfil their commitments to halt the two-year war in Gaza.



AFF

■ Palestinian children celebrate at a camp for displaced people in Nuseirat in the central Gaza Strip yesterday, following news of a Gaza ceasefire deal.

The UAE yesterday welcomed the announcement of the agreement.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs said that Trump had played a prominent role in urging all parties to take action to stop the war in the enclave.

The Ministry also thanked diplomats from Qatar, Egypt, and Turkey for their work on the crucial peace pact and expressed hope that it would prove to be a positive step in efforts to end the humanitarian suffering in Gaza and pave the way for a lasting settlement that guarantees the rights of Palestinians in the region.

It also reiterated the UAE's support for all regional and international efforts aimed at achieving peace while emphasising the need for unhindered humanitarian aid to pass freely into the enclave.

Relief tempered by grief

Eager for the bloodshed, displacement, and destruction to end, many Palestinians in Gaza expressed relief after hearing that Israel and Hamas had agreed to pause their devastating two-year war. But the relief was tempered by grief over immense losses and uncertainty about what comes next.

"Once we heard the news about the truce, we felt happy," said Ibrahim Shurrab from Khan Younis. "We ask God for this happiness to continue for our people, and for us to return to our homes despite all the pain and suffering," he told AP, speaking from Muwasi, an area now packed with tents sheltering displaced families.

Nevin Qudeeh said she felt the deepest sense of relief since the war began two years ago — but her joy, she added, would only be complete once she could go home. "We're still staying on the streets," she said quietly.

SEE ALSO PAGE 10

WHAT WE KNOW AND WHAT'S NEXT?

■ **Historic pause:** A breakthrough truce brokered by the US, Egypt, Qatar and Turkey halts two years of war in Gaza.

■ **Deal vote:** Israel's government was to vote on the accord yesterday; formal approval triggers the next phase.

■ **Troop pullback:** After approval, Israeli forces will withdraw from populated Gaza areas to agreed lines within 24 hours.

■ **Hostage timeline:** Once troops pull back, a 72-hour window begins for Hamas to release 20 living hostages, expected Monday.

■ **Prisoner swap:** Israel to free 250 life-sentence prisoners and 1,700 Gazans detained after October 2023.

■ **Aid flow:** Hundreds of humanitarian trucks will enter Gaza daily, with volumes increasing over time.

■ **Disarmament gap:** No mechanism yet agreed for Hamas to surrender its weapons — a key unresolved issue in Trump's 20-point peace plan.

■ **Gaza governance:** Hamas to step aside; Trump's plan proposes a technocratic Palestinian committee, later transitioning to Palestinian Authority control.

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